

OREGON CITY COURIER

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PLEASANT NEWS

It is to be noted that recent news dispatches announce that no rocks were thrown at the Liberty Bell while it was journeying through Eastern Oregon. From Pendleton comes the statement of a special agent of the Oregon-Washington Railroad & Navigation company that the rocks that hit the bell were dislodged by the jarring of the train as it passed through a cut. The special agent is reported to have investigated the matter thoroughly, and to have discovered that the small boys who were standing beside the track when the bell passed and when the rocks hit it had nothing to do with the bombardment.

This is pleasing news. Of course there may be carping critics who think it strange that the Liberty Bell special, proceeding carefully at a speed not in excess of 23 miles an hour, should loosen rocks upon the side of a railroad cut in such a curious way that they bounced down and hit the most hallowed relic of American independence—while passenger trains, dashing along over the same track before and after at much greater speeds had no windows smashed by similarly dislodged and bounding rocks. And there may be other carping critics who will think that "boys will be boys" and that the railroad company is gracefully lying to save the reputation of the state of Oregon. To some people, when a railroad company will admit that the sides of its cuts are so loose that a passing train is liable to jar rocks loose against the Liberty Bell, there is occasion for distrust and wonderment.

However, let that pass. Maybe the boys threw the stones in an exuberance of spirits; or maybe the vibration of the train jarred them loose. In either event, the railroad company has assumed the blame, and thus removes from the state the charge that the bell was not regarded by Oregonians with due respect. Real Americans who live within Oregon's borders will be glad that the "investigation" has resulted as announced, and they will hope that the explanation will be accepted elsewhere in the spirit in which it is made.

And, also, real, true, patriotic citizens who live in this state will for a long time feel grateful to the O. W. R. & N. for saving the reputation of the state at the expense of the reputation of its own cuts. That is truly heroic on the part of the railroad company.

Never again let it be said that the railroads have done nothing for this state!

SIGNS OF SENSE

It appears that with the advent of a democratic national administration there has come a change into the forestry service—and a change for the better. No longer do we have the Pinchot brand of conservation, which tied up thousands of acres of perfectly good agricultural land, and which made the West hate the federal government almost to the point of treason. Instead we are having something that approaches a common sense control of our forest reserves, and the people no longer feel that the public domain is being cared for by a bunch of theoretical fools who never saw a fir tree.

A recent report issued by the Forest Service tells of the efforts that are being made to eliminate from the timber reserves all land that is really agricultural land. To show what a change has come over the service since the days of the Pinchot fanatics, we quote the following enlightening paragraphs:

"The Government is withholding from agricultural entry all heavily timbered land until after the timber is cut off. As soon as this is done, the land will be opened to entry and settlers will be able to acquire directly from the Government, without cost, instead of having to pay from \$40 to \$60 an acre to land speculators. For example, on the Kaniku National Forest in Idaho and Washington, the Government's timber sales have been made to include much of

the remaining timbered agricultural land. Within eight years fully 10,000 acres will be made available for settlement. Permanent homes will be established by the settlers, and there will be available for the use of communities approximately \$225,000 for roads and schools, their legal share of the proceeds from the timber sales. Private ownership of heavily timbered agricultural land blocks farming development, says the article; government ownership insures such development under conditions that give opportunities to the small settler whose only capital is his strength and courageous perseverance.

"To show how thorough is the land classification work of the Forest Service, the Kootenai Valley in Montana may be taken as an example, continues the article. Here a large river winds for 150 miles thru the National Forest. At many points steep, densely forested hills drop down to the water's edge, making the valley a gorge or canyon. Here and there bars in the river have resulted in deposits of silt, forming long, narrow bottoms, or level islands, which are very fertile. Part way up the mountain slopes occasional benches of land afford a few acres of fertile soil. At first it was proposed to throw out the entire valley, a strip three miles in width on either side of the river. Ninety-five per cent of this belt, however, is non-agricultural land whose cultivation should not be attempted. Its best use to a local community, as well as to the country at large, is for timber growing. So instead of opening the whole valley to public entry by settlers, the Forest Service has painstakingly surveyed every little river bottom, island or bench, which contains enough arable land to support a home. Many of these patches are small, but their soil is so fertile that homes can be maintained on them by intensive truck farming or orcharding. In this fashion, more than three hundred farms have been carved out of this valley of the Kootenai National Forest."

If for nothing else than this bringing of common sense into the affairs of the national forests, the West has cause to be everlastingly grateful to the Wilson administration.

THE LOOPHOLE

Efforts of certain influences in Oregon City to so "regulate" jitneys that there will be no profit to be made by automobiles plying between the county seat and Portland may prove to be quite fruitless, even if freak ordinances designed for this purpose are bluffed through the council. Portland's city government has been having its share of fun with the jitneys of late, and has discovered that even if its ordinances hold good they leave a beautiful loophole for "interurban jitneys."

This discovery was made when the Portland police undertook to "regulate" certain jitneys that ply on a regular schedule between Gresham and the metropolis. These jits had not complied with the fancy provisions of the Portland ordinance, and the drivers of two cars were arrested and escorted to the police station. There an attorney employed by the jitneys in question politely told the police that the Gresham-Portland cars were not jitneys at all, but were public stages plying between Portland and Gresham. They carried no passengers to points within the city limits of Portland, but all their traffic was through and outside haul. And after discussion of the matter with Portland legal luminaries, the police let the Gresham jitney men go.

Efforts to embarrass the Portland-Oregon City jitneys may bring up a similar situation here, if the anti-jitney cohorts continue their campaign. The cars that run between the county seat and the metropolis travel about an eighth of a block within the city limits of Oregon City. They do not carry passengers to any point in Oregon City except their terminal stand, and they are like the Gresham jitneys, public stages operating between the county seat and Portland. And as such there is grave doubt if the city can "regulate"

Portland-Oregon City jitneys. It believes that they should pay a reasonable tax for the wear and tear they give the county roads. But, at the same time, the Courier does not like to see the city attempt to "regulate" these jitneys when such "regulation" is only a bluff to cut down their profits. Oregon City can stand all the various kinds of transportation them to any great degree.

The Courier holds no brief for the city—not the present one, but another quite similar to it—once upon a time let certain interests keep the Oregon Electric out of this city; and has been regretting it ever since. When the Carver line franchise was up, this former mistake was the subject of much councilmanic oratory.

And while the jitneys may not offer the same sort of service that is to be expected from a railroad company, they nevertheless provide a means of transportation to Oregon City—and the county seat needs all the means of communication with the rest of the world that it can get. Therefore it is poor policy to nag the jitneys—and it is still poorer policy to do it if it develops, as in the case of the Portland-Gresham cars, that the city has no authority so to act. Better leave the poor jits alone, and put it up to the county to tax them for the use of the county roads. It will be cheaper, less foolish, and in the long run it will prove the best thing that can be done.

THE KILLER

In the days of old when you conquering hero went out to battle he killed a sheep or a goat or a bull, or maybe a captive man or two, as an offering to the gods—so that he might get victory.

And today when your cinceited pol-

murderer he was made out." Before Gov. Whitman refused to commute Becker's sentence it developed that Rosenthal probably had been killed at the orders of Big Tim Sullivan and other high Tammany chieftains—not because Rosenthal was going to "squel on Becker," but because he was going to "squel on Tammany." Rosenthal was going to tell New York the identity of "the men higher up"—men so high up that they controlled Becker and the police department, as well as the gangs of gunmen on the East Side. It was for this that Rosenthal was shot down from the grey death-car—and Whitman knew it.

But Becker was head of the "strong-arm squad" of the New York police. For reasons of police politics he had blocked plans of Whitman the district attorney—just as other police officials fought Jerome; just as the police in New York have always warred against the county prosecutor—just as the police do everywhere. And Whitman saw a chance to "get" Becker for this, and at the same time to make a play to popular favor—a play that carried him into the governor's chair. And then, thinking that to pose as a killer would bring him fame and popularity elsewhere, Whitman kept on fighting Becker—the poor official goat of the Rosenthal mess—and not only did he see to it that he was electrocuted, but he charged Becker with having assisted his first wife to die an unnatural death.

That's the kind of a man Whitman is, it appears. That's the calibre of a "republican possibility for president." Well, maybe Becker died in a good cause, then. Maybe it was worth his death to thoroughly "show up" this Whitman praty.

But at that we'd rather be Becker

the supervisor system? Isn't that something nice to tell people outside—people who have never seen Clackamas county roads?

BUT WHAT ARE YOU GOING TO SAY TO PEOPLE WHO HAVE SEEN THE ROADS, or who have traveled over them? How are you going to justify the squandering of \$368,214.85 on the things that are called roads hereabouts?

WHAT WAS DONE WITH THE MONEY?

Wolf Howls

C. C. Chapman, who publishes the "Oregon Voter," tells of a dairy inspector who found a farmer straining milk through a pair of overalls, and then asks: "Why strain the milk, why not drink it straight?"

This reminds us of a butcher we once met, who sold us meat that developed crawling things after we took it home. We took the meat back, and showed the reptiles to the butcher. "That's funny," he said, "the weather has been cool, too. Meat things don't usually grow in my meat before the middle of summer."

It is odd how lightning strikes in unexpected places. And also how people who are not at all concerned sometimes take offense at remarks that appear in the newspapers. A couple of weeks ago in these Wolf Howls it was mentioned that some people who were doing what they called God's work ought to realize that God could do His own work quite

The Port Elizabeth (South Africa) ostrich feather market reopened last month, after a dull season. Here are some of the classes of ostrich feathers that were sold: "very ordinary feminas," "narrow feminas," "good feminas," "poor chicks, rubbish," "poor whites," "ordinary long blacks," "good drabs" and "ordinary tails." Sounds like a sort of social register, doesn't it?

teasing machines." Further reading brings out the fact that the teasers are wanted for "working pig's hair." It seems almost cruelly to use a machine to "tease" hair, doesn't it?

Better stuff next week.

TAFT AND BRYAN

Opposite Stands Taken by Party Leaders of Former Days

It is quite interesting to note the "sterling democracy" of W. J. Bryan these days. While President Wilson is being lauded by ex-president William Howard Taft, and while the former republican leader is calling upon all true Americans to support the President, Willie Bryan is saying but little. Mr. Taft has directly praised President Wilson's last German note, pronouncing it a document that will make much history. Mr. Bryan has not said a word about it.

On the other hand Bryan has yapped about the "unfitness" of including in the democratic platform planks favoring universal suffrage or prohibition. Universal suffrage and prohibition are at the heyday of their popularity now, and in condemning them for democrats, Bryan can hardly be said to be throwing roses in the path of the administration or his party.

And while considering Bryan's "negative support of Wilson," it is also interesting to note that the New York Tribune, the most fervidly "stand-pat republican" paper of the United States, recently remarked editorially that it was folly for the republicans to oppose Wilson at this time of national crisis. It would be better, said the Tribune, for republicans to endorse Wilson for president in 1916 than it would to put up an opposing candidate, for Wilson's handling of American affairs in the European crisis has been such as to make antagonism of him little less than treason.

With Taft and the Tribune speaking as they do of the President "friend Bryan" cuts a sorry figure in the democratic camp.

BIG DEED FILED

Molalla Branch of S. P. Turned Over to Parent System

Formal transfer of the Canby & Molalla railroad from control of the Portland, Eugene & Eastern to the Southern Pacific was made this week, when a deed covering the property was filed with Recorder Dedman. The consideration involved is given as \$115,506.43, and makes this the largest deed filed here since the transfer of the Oregon City locks to the government.

The Southern Pacific system is absorbing all the lines and trackage of the Portland, Eugene & Eastern, which was incorporated to control the electric lines of the big railroad system in Oregon. While the transfer is made to the Southern Pacific, actual operation of the old P. & E. lines will be under the title of the Oregon & California railroad—a subsidiary of the Southern Pacific.

The Courier for job printing.

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lines that it can get. The city politician goes out to make a race for the republican nomination for the presidency he kills a man—as to carry to popular favor.

Meaning this Whitman person, governor of New York, and spoken of as the head end of a ticket of which Jonathan Bourne shall be the hind end.

The only reason why Whitman refused to commute the sentence of Charles Becker was because he thought that if he deviated from the plan of killing Becker, which he originated when he was district attorney of New York, he would be weakening his political chances. Whitman knew there was a doubt in the Becker case, he nearly broke down when he gave Becker's wife an interview—an interview which he tried dishonorably to dodge, by the way—he besmirched Becker's character at the last minute, and he set his biased judgment up against everything, saying that HE "knew" there could be no new evidence. In other words Whitman killed Becker to make a political boom.

And when Becker thus died, so did also all future chance for Whitman in public office.

As Mrs. Becker told the governor when she was making a last plea for her husband's life: "Charles Becker was no saint, but he was not the foul

presence of his own conscience.

THROWING IT AWAY

According to a report compiled by John Y. Richardson, expert accountant, and published under the records of the insurance commissioner, Clackamas county spent \$368,214 for its roads in 1914. Only four counties in the state spent more than this—Multnomah, Clatsop, Jackson and Columbia. And the last three spent more because they floated bond issues.

According to the report, then, Clackamas county spent more of its taxpayers' money for road work than any other county save Multnomah during 1914. Bond issue expenses do not come out of the taxpayers' pockets the first year. Clackamas county spent road funds at the rate of \$9.99 per capita, while Multnomah spent it at the rate of \$2.75 per capita. And these figures do not include sums that were spent on bridges and ferries.

WHERE IN THE NAME OF SERVICE DID THIS \$368,214.85 GO?

Over three hundred and sixty thousand dollars spent on roads in this county in one year—last year. Isn't that a fine thing to have on record as a state document? Doesn't that make you proud of your county and

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